

Fatter Platters

Desktop hard disks are approaching terabyte territory. Does larger equate to better? SATA or IDE? What brand? Need answers? Read on!

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Quick: what's the slowest device in your system? Chances are you'd say "my CPU," or "my DVD-ROM." If we were to enquire as to the most *important* device in your PC, chances are you'd say it's the CPU.

Your hard disk is by far the slowest of all your PC components and yet perhaps the most important device inside your PC. Simple reason: your data resides on your hard drive. It's irreplaceable. Warranties mean nothing: what's worth more—a new, empty hard disk, or all the data you'd hoarded and all the programs you'd installed?

Now, not only are hard disks faster and bigger—*much* bigger—than they were a couple of years ago, prices have fallen so drastically, gigabytes almost cost peanuts. So what do you do with all that storage? Well, with our games going multi-gigabyte and entire movies on our disks, it seems no amount of storage space will ever satiate us.

Remember it's us, the users, and our usage patterns that

dictate terms to hard disk manufacturers, not the other way around. We wanted speed, we needed storage, and craved reliability, didn't we? Well, how does that age-old adage go—"be careful what you ask for"?

Features

We received a lot of Serial ATA drives for this test, all except one of these were SATA 2 compliant. We also received a few Parallel ATA drives. Considering the price difference between them, if your motherboard supports Serial ATA, simply go for it.

The SATA drives from Seagate, Samsung and Western Digital had pins that could be jumpered to force them to operate in SATA 1 mode (150 MBps). This is useful in case your Serial ATA controller is SATA 1; operating without the jumper could cause compatibility issues. The WD drives came with SATA 2 support; no jumpers. The Hitachi series deserves special mention for the hassle involved with enabling SATA 2 mode. They're capable of 300 MBps operation, but come with 150 MBps mode enabled.

Enabling SATA 2

